

MASOCHISM, THE AMERICAN WAY

The American way often amounts to masochism rather than pleasure. When we fail at something we're told to tough it out rather than stop, reevaluate, then switch to something we're good at. Masochism and sadism turn us on, whether in movies, cockfights, or a grinding, bone-wrenching football game or ride on the Lexington Avenue express. I'm not talking about the leather parlors near New York's piers or on San Francisco's Polk Street, but about healthy, well-rounded American masochism.

Our forefathers called it self-denial. Phillip Greven, a colonial history scholar, wrote a book about our past called *The Protestant Temperament* (Knopf 1977). You won't find Greven's book on many yuppie bookshelves. But it goes a long way toward explaining why pleasure brings guilt and suffering brings pleasure.

Greven found that our "evangelical" forefathers lived with total hostility to the self. They searched for ways to abase, deny, and destroy their sense of self-worth and selfhood. Some of these evangelicals left diaries. Their entries are a long way from what a pubescent girl might start with "Dear Diary." One man said, for example, that "the very thought of any joy arising in me . . . is nauseous and contemptible to me."

Not all early settlers were evangelicals. A second group—Greven calls them moderates—weren't quite as stern. (Genteels, a third group, developed later in the eighteenth century.) John and Abigail Adams were moderates. Greven says that "both John and Abigail Adams felt most comfortable when denying themselves something they desired or enjoyed." Adams became president of the United States, but for him "a life in . . . politics was actually a form of self-denial, for it kept him from his beloved wife and children and his house and farm."

John Adams drove himself so hard he had to go to New England to restore his health. While up there he wrote in his